

CORPORATE POLICY REVIEW REPORT

Privacy Policy & Data Protection

A Case Analysis of Zoho Corporation

Student Name: kaushik .D

Register Number: 5272510207

Course: B.Com (Fintech with AI)

Activity Title: Corporate Policy Review Report

Organization Reviewed: Zoho

Policy Name: Privacy Policy & Data Protection

1. Introduction

Zoho Corporation is an Indian multinational software company headquartered in Chennai, Tamil Nadu, and founded in 1996 by Sridhar Vembu, Tony Thomas and Shailesh Kumar Davey. Zoho builds a large suite of cloud-based business applications, including Zoho CRM, Zoho Mail, Zoho Books, Zoho Workplace and Zoho One, which are used by millions of businesses and individuals across the world. Because almost every one of Zoho's products runs on the cloud, the company constantly collects, stores and processes large volumes of personal and business data belonging to its customers, their employees, and their own customers in turn.

For this activity, the corporate policy selected for review is Zoho's Privacy Policy and Data Protection framework. A privacy policy is the document through which a company explains what personal information it collects, why it collects it, how it uses and shares that

information, and what rights individuals have over their own data. For a software company like Zoho, whose entire business model depends on customers trusting it with sensitive data, the privacy policy is not just a legal formality but a core part of the company's brand identity.

The purpose of this review is to study Zoho's publicly published Privacy Policy in detail, understand how it is structured, examine how it aligns with major data protection laws such as the GDPR and India's Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023, and evaluate its strengths and possible gaps. Unlike the review of Zoho's Employee Code of Conduct, which had to be built mostly from culture and public statements, this review is based on an actual, detailed and publicly available legal document, which makes it possible to examine the policy directly.

2. Policy Overview

Name and nature of the policy: The policy under review is Zoho's Privacy Policy, published at zoho.com/privacy.html, and last updated on 22nd December 2025. It is a single, unified document that covers every Zoho website, product and mobile application that links to it. It is written as a legal document but is structured with a short, plain-language summary at the top, followed by the full detailed policy text, so that both ordinary users and legal or compliance professionals can understand it.

Scope of the policy: The policy applies to all Zoho Group entities and to all Zoho websites, cloud products and mobile applications that link to it, unless a specific product has its own separate privacy policy. It is divided into three clear parts: Part I, which covers information that Zoho itself collects and controls, such as account and website visitor data; Part II, which covers "service data," meaning the customer or employee data that Zoho's business customers store on Zoho's platforms while using products like Zoho CRM or Zoho Mail; and Part III, which covers general topics such as security, data retention, international transfers and how the policy itself may change.

Employees/stakeholders covered: The policy is directed at several groups of stakeholders: individual users who sign up for a personal Zoho account, business customers who use Zoho's products to store their own customers' and employees' data, website visitors, and even third parties such as reselling partners, marketplace application developers, and domain registrars with whom Zoho shares limited data. Zoho's own employees are also bound by the confidentiality and access-control commitments described in the policy, since they are the ones who may come into contact with customer data while providing support.

Key objectives: The policy's central objective, repeated throughout the document, is that Zoho will collect only the minimum information it genuinely needs, will never sell personal information for advertising revenue, will give users meaningful control and rights over their own data, and will apply strong technical and organisational safeguards to protect the data it holds.

3. Key Provisions of the Policy

Data Collection

Zoho collects information in three main ways: information that users actively provide (such as name, email address, company name and country during account signup, or payment details when purchasing a subscription), information collected automatically (such as IP address, browser type, device information and usage patterns through cookies and application logs), and information received from third parties (such as when a user signs in through Google or LinkedIn, or when a reselling partner passes on a lead). Notably, Zoho states that it does not store full credit card numbers, only the cardholder's name, address, and the last four digits of the card.

Consent

For users in the European Economic Area, Zoho explains that it relies on one of several legal bases for collecting and using data: contractual necessity, legitimate business interest, or the user's consent. Where consent is the legal basis, Zoho gives users the right to withdraw that consent at any time, although this does not undo processing that has already taken place. Optional information, such as a profile photo, is clearly marked as optional, and users can choose not to fill in non-mandatory form fields.

Data Usage

Collected information is used to provide and maintain the requested service, communicate with customers about their accounts and support requests, analyse usage patterns to improve products, detect fraud and abuse, and, where the user has not opted out, to send information about new products and offers. Zoho makes an important distinction here between information it collects for its own purposes (Part I data) and "service data," which is the customer or employee data that a business customer stores inside Zoho's applications; Zoho processes this service data only according to that customer's own instructions, since the business customer, not Zoho, owns and controls it.

Data Sharing

Zoho states clearly that it does not sell personal information to anyone. Limited sharing does take place in specific, defined situations: with other Zoho Group entities, with third-party service providers such as payment processors who are bound by confidentiality obligations, with domain registrars as required by ICANN rules when a domain is registered through Zoho, and with the developer of a marketplace application if a user installs that application. Zoho also states that it will disclose personal information where legally required, for example to comply with a law, prevent fraud, or protect user safety.

Data Retention

Personal information collected under Part I is retained only as long as necessary for the purpose it was collected for, after which it is deleted or anonymised. For service data held on behalf of business customers, Zoho states that once an account is terminated, the data is deleted from the active database during the next scheduled clean-up, which happens once every six months, and is then deleted from backups within a further three months.

Data Security

Zoho states that it applies appropriate administrative, technical and physical safeguards to protect data from unauthorised access, use, disclosure or destruction. It backs this up with independent third-party certifications, including ISO/IEC 27001 for information security management, SOC 2 Type II for security and availability controls, and ISO/IEC 27701 for privacy information management, which is a specific extension of ISO 27001 focused on privacy. Zoho also maintains a separate, detailed Security Policy document and has an internal Privacy Incident Response process for handling any data breach.

User Rights

The policy grants data subjects a full set of rights modelled on the GDPR: the right to access their data, the right to correct inaccurate data, the right to request erasure, the right to restrict processing, the right to data portability, the right to object to certain uses such as direct marketing, and the right to file a complaint with a supervisory authority. Importantly, Zoho states that it extends these same rights to all users worldwide, not only to those located in the European Economic Area where the law technically requires it.

4. Compliance and Governance Analysis

Zoho's Privacy Policy is shaped by, and must satisfy, several overlapping legal frameworks, since the company operates globally but is headquartered in India:

- The General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR), the European Union's comprehensive data protection law, which requires a lawful basis for processing, grants data subjects the rights described above, and requires companies to appoint a Data Protection Officer (DPO) where applicable. Zoho has appointed a DPO and is prepared to sign a GDPR-compliant Data Processing Addendum (DPA) with business customers.
- India's Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023 (DPDP Act), which is India's first comprehensive data protection law. It applies to digital personal data processed within India as well as, in some cases, data of Indian residents processed outside India. It requires clear notice and consent, purpose limitation, data minimisation, and reporting of data breaches to the Data Protection Board of India. As an Indian-headquartered company, Zoho's practice of minimal data collection, defined retention periods, and breach response procedures aligns closely with these expectations, even though the Act was still being implemented in phases.
- The Information Technology Act, 2000, and its associated Sensitive Personal Data Rules, which historically governed data protection obligations for Indian companies before the DPDP Act, and which the DPDP Act is gradually replacing.
- Industry security standards and certifications, namely ISO/IEC 27001, ISO/IEC 27701 and SOC 2 Type II, which are not laws but independently audited

standards that give customers assurance that Zoho's internal security and privacy controls meet a recognised international benchmark.

On governance, the presence of a named Data Protection Officer, a published international contact address for data protection queries, a dedicated privacy email address, and a formal Data Processing Addendum process together show a reasonably mature privacy governance structure. The fact that the policy explicitly separates "data that Zoho controls" from "data that Zoho merely processes on a customer's behalf" is also a strong piece of governance discipline, because it mirrors the controller/processor distinction that both the GDPR and the DPDP Act rely on.

5. Policy Evaluation

Strengths

- Business model alignment: Zoho's core promise, repeated for almost 25 years, is that it does not make money from advertising and therefore has little incentive to misuse personal data the way some free, ad-funded platforms might.
- Clear structure: Dividing the policy into a short plain-language summary and a longer legal document, and further splitting the legal document into Part I, Part II and Part III, makes a naturally complex topic easier to follow, which supports the goal of simple and direct language that the policy itself states.
- Global extension of EEA-style rights: Extending GDPR-style data subject rights to all users worldwide, not only EEA residents, goes beyond the bare legal minimum and reflects a genuinely user-friendly approach.
- Independent certification: Backing the written policy with ISO 27001, ISO 27701 and SOC 2 Type II certification gives the commitments real, externally verified weight rather than leaving them as unverified promises.

Effectiveness and Practicality

The policy appears practical to implement because Zoho has built supporting infrastructure around it, such as a dedicated Data Processing Addendum request form, a named Data Protection Officer with a published contact address, and product-specific GDPR compliance settings inside tools like Zoho CRM and Zoho Analytics. This suggests the policy is not just a static legal document but is actively supported by technical features.

Gaps and Limitations

- Length and complexity: By the policy's own admission, it is "longer than we would like," and while the summary section helps, the full document remains a long read for an average user, which can limit how many people genuinely engage with it in detail.
- Do Not Track signals are not honoured: The policy openly states that Zoho does not currently act on browser "Do Not Track" requests, which is a minor but real gap compared to a small number of more privacy-maximalist companies.

- Dependence on the customer for service data rights: Because Zoho processes "service data" only as instructed by its business customers, an individual whose data is stored inside someone else's Zoho account (for example, an employee whose HR data is stored in a client's Zoho People account) must approach that business customer directly to exercise data rights, rather than approaching Zoho, which can be a confusing extra step for that individual.

Comparison with Good Practice

Compared to the ad-funded business models of some large technology platforms, Zoho's no-advertising commitment is a genuine structural advantage from a privacy standpoint. Compared to strict global best practice, however, a fully privacy-maximalist company would also honour Do Not Track signals and might offer a simpler, shorter "layered" summary in addition to the current one. Overall, Zoho's policy compares favourably with typical SaaS industry practice and reflects a generally strong, above-average approach to privacy governance.

6. Business Relevance

A strong privacy policy is especially important in modern business because data has become one of the most valuable and most sensitive assets that any company handles. For a cloud software company like Zoho, whose entire product suite depends on customers trusting it with confidential business data, privacy is not a side issue but a central part of the value proposition.

The impact on customers is direct: businesses that use Zoho's products to manage their own customer relationships, HR records or finances need assurance that this data will not leak, be misused, or be sold to advertisers, since a breach of that trust could damage their own business as much as Zoho's. The impact on individual users and employees whose personal data passes through Zoho's systems is equally important, since the policy's data subject rights give them a way to access, correct or delete their information even when they are not Zoho's direct customer.

In terms of risk management, ethics, compliance and governance, a well-maintained privacy policy reduces Zoho's legal and regulatory risk under laws like the GDPR and the DPDP Act, supports ethical business practice by avoiding the data-for-advertising conflict of interest that many competitors face, and strengthens corporate governance by clearly defining roles such as the Data Protection Officer and formal processes such as the Data Processing Addendum.

7. Recommendations

- Introduce a shorter, layered privacy notice (in addition to the existing summary and full policy) using simple visual icons or a short video, to make key points even more accessible to non-technical users.

- Reconsider the current position on Do Not Track signals as more browsers and regulators move toward standardising them, so that Zoho's practice keeps pace with its stated privacy-first identity.
- Provide a simpler, clearly signposted pathway for individuals whose data is held as "service data" inside another company's Zoho account, so they can more easily identify who to contact to exercise their data rights.
- Continue to align proactively with India's Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023 as its rules are fully notified and implemented, given that Zoho is headquartered in India and a large share of its workforce and infrastructure is based there.
- Publish periodic, simplified transparency updates (for example, a short annual privacy report) summarising any policy changes, security incidents, or new certifications, to keep both individual users and business customers continuously informed beyond the standard email notifications.

8. Conclusion

Overall, Zoho's Privacy Policy and Data Protection framework reflects a genuinely privacy-conscious approach that is unusual for a company of its scale, built around a long-standing, explicit refusal to monetise user data through advertising. The policy is clearly structured, backed by internationally recognised security certifications, supported by a named Data Protection Officer and formal compliance tools, and extends strong data subject rights to users worldwide rather than only where the law strictly requires it.

The key learning from this review is that a privacy policy works best when it is not treated as a purely legal or defensive document, but is instead aligned with the company's actual business model; because Zoho does not depend on advertising revenue, its privacy commitments are easier to keep than they might be for a company whose profits depend on user data. At the same time, even a strong policy like Zoho's has room to improve in areas such as document length, Do Not Track practices, and clarity for individuals whose data is processed indirectly through a business customer.

This review reinforces the broader importance of effective privacy and data protection policies in modern business: such policies protect individuals' fundamental right to privacy, help companies comply with an increasingly complex global regulatory landscape spanning laws like the GDPR and India's DPDP Act, and ultimately build the long-term customer trust that any data-driven business depends on.

9. References

Zoho Corporation, "Privacy Policy," available at zoho.com/privacy.html (last updated 22 December 2025).

Zoho Corporation, "GDPR," available at zoho.com/gdpr.html.

Zoho Corporation, "Security Policy," available at zoho.com/security.html.

Zoho Corporation, "Compliance Certifications," available at zoho.com/compliance.html.

General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR), Regulation (EU) 2016/679, European Union.

The Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023, Government of India.

The Information Technology Act, 2000, Government of India.

Wikipedia, "Zoho Corporation," en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Zoho_Corporation.